



Evidence and Inference Lab

Grade 8 • North Carolina • Reading

RL.8.1

Cite the textual evidence that most strongly supports an analysis of explicit statements and inferences drawn from a literary text. An 80-minute block-period packet with warm-up, guided practice, partner discussion, independent practice, small-group work, and a full answer key.

PRINT • TEACH • REVISIT



Plan the 80-minute block

Level and alignment

Grade 8 · North Carolina · Reading; RL.8.1 — Cite the textual evidence that most strongly supports an analysis of what the text says explicitly as well as inferences drawn from the text.

What is included

Cover; teacher guide; vocabulary and lesson preview; original passage; warm-up (2 items); guided practice with organizer (4 items); partner discussion (3 items); independent practice (6 items); small-group intervention and enrichment (4 items); exit ticket; complete answer key; access and sources page.

Suggested pacing (80 minutes)

Warm-up 8 min · passage + guided practice 25 min · partner discussion 12 min · independent practice 20 min · small-group work 10 min · exit ticket 5 min.

Preparation

Print student pages separately from the answer key. Review the passage and organizer before class. No outside novel or paid app required.

Student directions

Read the passage carefully. Use evidence from the text to support every answer. Quote or closely paraphrase the text and name the paragraph.



Before you read

Key vocabulary

Lesson focus

Explicit evidence is stated directly in the text; an inference is a reasonable conclusion built from evidence plus what a reader already knows. At grade 8, "most strongly supports" means choosing the single best piece of evidence, not just any evidence that fits — weigh competing details and explain why one supports the analysis better than another.

Model 1 — Paragraph 2 says Marcus "read the acceptance letter four times, then folded it into his back pocket instead of showing anyone." What is the strongest evidence for an inference that he is unsure how to feel about the news?

The detail that he read it four times but told no one is the strongest evidence — rereading suggests he is still processing the news, and folding it away instead of sharing it suggests he is not ready to react publicly, which together support uncertainty rather than simple excitement or disappointment.

Model 2 — Between "the gym was hot" and "she wiped her palms on her shorts three times before the serve," which detail more strongly supports an inference about nervousness, and why?

The second detail more strongly supports nervousness because it is a specific, repeated physical action tied directly to the moment of pressure, while "the gym was hot" is a general environmental fact that could support many different inferences.



WARM-UP

Warm-up · Before you read

Answer using what you already know. Five minutes.

1. What does paragraph 1 state explicitly about how Marcus applied to the magnet school?

2. What is the strongest evidence that Marcus is anxious about how Dante will react to the news? Cite it and explain why it is the strongest choice.



The Acceptance Letter

1. Marcus had applied to the magnet arts high school without telling his older brother, Dante, who had been rejected from the same program two years earlier and had not mentioned it since. Marcus kept his own application folded inside a library book so it would not turn up in a drawer.
2. The letter came on a Tuesday, while Dante was at practice. Marcus read the acceptance letter four times, then folded it into his back pocket instead of showing anyone. He went to his room and closed the door, which he almost never did.
3. At dinner, their mother asked if anything interesting had happened that day. Marcus said no. Dante, half-listening, asked to be passed the rice. Marcus passed it and said nothing else for the rest of the meal.
4. Over the next week, Marcus carried the letter with him — to school, to the bus stop, once even into the shower, where it sat on the sink until he remembered and moved it. He did not read it again. He also did not throw it away.
5. On Saturday, Dante found him in the garage, sitting on an overturned bucket, the letter open on his knee. "You've had that a week," Dante said. It was not a question. Marcus had not heard him come in.
6. "I didn't want it to be a thing," Marcus said. "You didn't get in, and I—" He stopped. Dante sat down on a second bucket, close enough that their shoulders nearly touched.
7. "I got in your way for two years without meaning to," Dante said. "Read it out loud. I want to hear how it sounds when it's actually happening to someone." Marcus looked at him for a long moment before he understood that Dante meant it.
8. Marcus read the letter aloud, once, in the garage, with the door up and the evening light coming in sideways across the concrete. When he finished, Dante didn't say anything about his own rejection at all. He just said, "You should tell Mom tonight," and meant it kindly.
9. That night at dinner, Marcus told her. Dante, across the table, was the first to smile.



Guided practice · Evidence organizer

Work through this organizer together before independent practice.

It Says	It Means	And So
Quote or closely paraphrase the text.	Explain the evidence in your own words.	State the inference or analysis it supports.

1. What explicit action does Marcus take with the letter in paragraph 2?

2. Which detail from paragraph 3 most strongly supports an inference that Marcus is deliberately hiding something at dinner, and why is it stronger than the fact that he "said no"?

3. What explicit detail in paragraph 4 shows Marcus cannot decide what to do with the letter?

4. What can you infer about why Marcus does not throw the letter away, even though he also will not talk about it? Cite the strongest evidence.

Partner discussion

Discuss each question with a partner before writing a joint response.

1. What explicit statement in paragraph 5 shows Dante already suspected something?

2. Between "It was not a question" and "Marcus had not heard him come in," which more strongly supports the inference that Dante had been quietly paying attention to Marcus all week? Explain.

3. What explicit reason does Marcus give in paragraph 6 for hiding the letter?



Independent practice

Work independently. Cite evidence from the text in every answer.

1. What can you infer about Dante's feelings toward his own rejection from paragraph 7? Cite the strongest evidence.

2. What explicit physical detail in paragraph 7 shows a shift toward closeness between the brothers?

3. Which is the stronger evidence that Dante has genuinely moved past resentment: sitting close to Marcus, or asking him to read the letter aloud? Explain your reasoning.



Independent practice

Work independently. Cite evidence from the text in every answer.

4. What explicit detail describes the setting as Marcus reads the letter aloud in paragraph 8?

5. What can you infer from Dante saying nothing about his own rejection after Marcus finishes reading? Cite evidence.

6. What explicit words does Dante use to encourage Marcus at the end of paragraph 8?



Small-group work

Use with students who need additional support.

1. What is the strongest evidence in the whole story that Dante's support is sincere rather than reluctant? Justify your choice.

2. Explain the difference between explicit and inferred information using two examples from this story.

Small-group work

Use with students ready for additional challenge.

1. A classmate claims the story is only about sibling rivalry. Using the strongest textual evidence, explain why that analysis is incomplete.

2. Identify one place in the story where two different inferences could reasonably be drawn from the same evidence, and explain both.

Exit ticket

Answer independently to show what you learned today.

1. Write one full inference about Dante, and identify the single strongest piece of evidence that supports it, explaining why it beats at least one other possible piece of evidence.



Exit ticket · self-assessment

Rate today's work:

4 — I can teach this to someone else.

3 — I can do this independently.

2 — I can do this with help.

1 — I need to revisit this with my teacher.



Answer key

1. He applied without telling Dante, and kept the application folded inside a library book so it would not be found.
2. The strongest evidence is that he hid the application inside a library book (paragraph 1) and later hid the acceptance letter in his pocket instead of telling anyone (paragraph 2); these two deliberate acts of concealment, both aimed at avoiding Dante finding out, more strongly support anxiety than a single detail like closing his door would alone.
3. He reads it four times, then folds it into his back pocket instead of showing anyone, and closes his bedroom door.
4. "Marcus... said nothing else for the rest of the meal" is stronger, because staying unusually silent for an entire meal is a sustained behavior change, while a single "no" answer alone could simply mean nothing happened that day.
5. He carries it everywhere for a week, including into the shower, but does not read it again and does not throw it away.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Answer key

6. He likely still wants to keep the acceptance real to himself even while afraid to share it; the strongest evidence is that he carries it everywhere, including into the shower (paragraph 4), which shows the letter matters enough to stay physically close even without being discussed.

7. "You've had that a week," Dante said — stated as fact, not a question, showing he already knew or had guessed.

8. "It was not a question" more strongly supports it, because it shows Dante already had enough information to state a fact rather than ask, which requires him to have been observing Marcus over time, while "Marcus had not heard him come in" only shows Marcus was distracted in that moment.

9. He says he "didn't want it to be a thing," and starts to reference Dante not getting in before stopping himself.

10. He seems to have made peace with it or wants to face it directly rather than avoid it; the strongest evidence is his direct request, "Read it out loud. I want to hear how it sounds when it's actually happening to someone," which shows he is choosing to engage with the painful topic rather than avoid it.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Answer key

11. Dante sits down on a second bucket, close enough that their shoulders nearly touch.
12. Asking Marcus to read the letter aloud is stronger evidence, because it is an active choice to face the source of possible resentment directly, while sitting close is a smaller, more passive gesture that could occur without resolving deeper feelings.
13. The garage door is up and the evening light is coming in sideways across the concrete.
14. It suggests Dante is intentionally keeping the moment focused on Marcus rather than making it about himself; paragraph 8 states he "didn't say anything about his own rejection at all" immediately after the reading, which is a deliberate omission given the topic's relevance.
15. "You should tell Mom tonight."

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Answer key

16. The strongest evidence is that Dante is "the first to smile" when Marcus tells their mother (paragraph 9); a genuine, immediate positive reaction at the emotional climax carries more weight than his earlier words alone, since actions in the story's final moment confirm what his words suggested.

17. Explicit: the text directly states Marcus read the letter four times (paragraph 2). Inferred: the reader must conclude from his silence and hiding behavior that he feels anxious or unsure, since the story never states his emotions directly.

18. The story is more about reconciliation than rivalry; the strongest evidence against a rivalry-only reading is Dante's statement, "I got in your way for two years without meaning to" (paragraph 7), which shows him taking responsibility and moving toward connection rather than continuing to compete.

19. Dante finding Marcus in the garage (paragraph 5) could support either "Dante has been quietly worried about Marcus" or "Dante happened to walk in by chance"; the story leans toward the first because Dante already knows how long Marcus has had the letter, which is unlikely to be coincidence.

20. Answers vary; require a clear inference about Dante plus one specific cited detail, with an explanation of why that detail supports the inference more strongly than another available detail.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Access, sources, and license

AIG

Ask for a second interpretation, a counterexample, or a student-written item at the same rigor, with an explanation of the choice.

504

Follow the individual plan: extended time, breaks, enlarged print, reduced copying, or an alternate response method as documented.

EC

Pre-teach key vocabulary before reading. Model the first guided-practice item aloud. Accept oral or dictated responses when appropriate.

ESL

Preview key vocabulary with examples. Allow brief home-language discussion before independent writing. Provide sentence starters for open-response items.

Official alignment source • accessed September 18, 2026

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NC ELA Standard Course of Study, Grade 8: <https://www.thecorestandards.org/ELA-Literacy/RL/8/1/>

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